

Decorative margins and headings were inscribed by hand before the printed sheets were bound together.

Gothic printed type modeled on German hand-written script.

“... the only supreme head on Earth of the Church in England.”

DESCRIPTION OF HENRY VIII OF ENGLAND IN THE ACT OF SUPREMACY, 1534

Brandenburg, Brunswick, and others adopted Lutheranism. Each state took control of the church, strengthening the hold of the ruler over his people.

Worldwide appeal

The appeal of Lutheranism was not restricted to Germany. In 1527 Gustavus Vasa, the ruler of Sweden (which had only gained independence from Denmark–Norway in 1523), seized church lands to provide funds for his new state. He then reformed the new state church along Lutheran lines. A similar process saw the adoption of Lutheranism in Denmark–Norway in 1536. In England, a break with the church in Rome came about after the pope refused Henry VIII a divorce from his wife, Catherine of Aragon. Henry replaced the Pope as head of the English church.

Political fallout

The political response to the Lutheran reformation was led by Emperor Charles V. However, his vast territorial domains in Europe brought him in conflict with, among others, France. War between these two sides, as well as between Charles and the growing might of the Muslim Ottoman



The Renaissance papacy

Pope Leo X became a cardinal while still a child. He promoted the sale of indulgences to pay for the rebuilding of St. Peter's Basilica, prompting Luther's protest against this practice in 1517.

was summoned to present his views at an imperial Diet (parliament) at Worms in front of Holy Roman Emperor Charles V, who ruled over much of Europe. Luther refused to retract his views and, having already been excommunicated (expelled from the church) by the pope, was now outlawed by the emperor. His response was to set up his own independent church. He also set to work translating the Bible into German; previous editions of the Bible had been transcribed in Latin—Luther's edition would allow people to read the Bible in their native language for the first time.

Part of the power of Luther's teachings lay in their appeal to German identity. Germany at this point was made up of many independent states, nominally controlled by Emperor Charles V. German princes wishing to exert their power against the dominance of Charles V saw Luther's teachings as a way of breaking both imperial and church control over Germany. What began as a religious debate soon became a political revolt. In 1524 the Peasants' War broke out in southwest Germany as a result of economic hardship in the region. A league of German princes, supported by Luther, crushed the revolt in 1526 with great loss of life. The revolt horrified Luther as much as it did the secular leaders it was aimed at. One by one, the north German states of Saxony, Hesse,

empire in the Mediterranean and Balkans (see pp. 246–47), meant he could not devote all of his resources to crushing the Lutherans in Germany. Charles defeated the Lutherans in battle at Mühlberg in 1547, but he could not crush them politically. A religious and political compromise was finally reached by the Peace of Augsburg in 1555, by which the emperor allowed each prince within the empire to choose between Catholicism and Lutheranism and impose that belief upon his subjects.



THE REFORMATION

The Protestant Reformation began in Germany in 1517 and had a profound and disruptive effect across Europe well into the next century.

